



All smiles: A jubilant Services side celebrates after winning the 77th Santosh Trophy final against Goa. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Santosh Trophy grapples with the changing state of Indian football

In the 21st century, the Santosh Trophy remains popular in West Bengal, Kerala, and the Northeast, but the players' **calibre doesn't match** its storied legacy.

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In the post-independence era, the National Football Championship for Santosh Trophy, started in 1941 by Sir Manmatha Nath Roy Chowdhary, the then-president of the Indian Football Association, was the closest the country had to a national tournament.

Though competitions such as the Rovers Cup (started in 1890) and Durand Cup (started in 1888) continued, the Santosh Trophy created a place for itself, with coaches and players from the national team taking part.

Balai Das Chatterjee, the first coach of the Indian football team, won the Santosh Trophy six times with Bengal between 1959 and 1969.

Almost half of India's gold medal-winning squad at the 1962 Asian Games comprised Santosh Trophy champions Peter Thangaraj, Chuni Goswami, P. K. Banerjee, D. Ethiraj, Tulsidas Balaram, and Pradyut Barman.

O. Chandrasekhar also got added to the list when he lifted the trophy in 1963 with Maharashtra.

In the 21st century, the Santosh Trophy continues to draw

considerable attention from football enthusiasts in West Bengal, Kerala, and the Northeast. Nonetheless, the calibre of players participating in the tournament falls short of the standards set by their predecessors.

When a packed stadium at the Malappuram District Sports Complex Stadium cheered every move by the local team, Kerala, against Bengal in the 2022 Santosh Trophy final, neither team featured a national team regular.

Instead, youngsters such as Jesin TK, Noufal PN, and Dilip Oraon took centre stage, helping Kerala win the